

Ulmus rubra (Ulmaceae)

Slippery Elm

This marvellous herb is a gentle and effective remedy for irritated states of the mucous membranes of the chest, urinary tubules, stomach, and intestines. It was used in many different ways by Native Americans—as a poultice for wounds, boils, ulcers, and inflamed eyes, and internally for fevers, colds, and bowel complaints. Slippery elm has a strongly mucilaginous “slippery” taste and texture.



Slippery elm produces red-brown fruit, each consisting of a single seed, in summer.

Habitat & Cultivation

Slippery elm is a native of the U.S. and Canada, and is most commonly found growing in the Appalachian Mountains. The tree thrives on high ground and dry soil. The inner bark of the trunk and branches is collected in spring.

Related Species

White elm (*U. americana*) is used in a similar way to slippery elm, and was taken for coughs by the Mohicans. In Europe, the dried bark of elm (*Ulmus* spp.) was used as a demulcent, and was first mentioned by Dioscorides in the 1st century CE.

Key Constituents

- Mucilage
- Starch
- Tannins

Key Actions

- Demulcent
- Emollient
- Nutritive
- Laxative

Research

■ **Mucilage** There is limited research into slippery elm, but its action as an herb with large quantities of mucilage is well understood. When the herb comes into direct contact with inflamed surfaces such as the skin or the intestinal membranes, it soothes and coats the irritated tissue, protects it from injury, and draws out toxins or irritants.

■ **Reflex action** When slippery elm is taken internally, it is thought likely that it causes a reflex stimulation of nerve endings in the stomach and intestines that leads to secretion of mucus by the membranes of the urinary tract.

Traditional & Current Uses

■ **Nourishing** Taken regularly, slippery elm is a nutritious and soothing food that acts as a prebiotic, supporting beneficial bacterial growth within the gut. It is excellent as a baby food and during convalescence.

■ **Digestive disorders** Slippery elm is a particularly soothing herb and can bring instant relief to acidity, diarrhea, and gastroenteritis. It will also help alleviate conditions such as colic, inflammation of the gut, constipation, hemorrhoids, diverticulitis, and irritable bowel syndrome.

■ **Urinary problems** This herb is a useful remedy for urinary problems such as chronic cystitis.

■ Respiratory conditions

Slippery elm has been used to treat all manner of chest conditions and has a soothing effect on everything from coughs and bronchitis to pleurisy and tuberculosis.



Slippery elm

A large tree growing to 59 ft (18 m) with a brown trunk and rough gray-white bark on the branches.

Parts Used

Inner bark of 10-year-old slippery elm trees is collected in spring and powdered.

Bark contains mucilage that soothes irritated tissues



Dried bark



Fresh bark

Key Preparations & Their Uses



Infusion Mix 1 heaped tsp with 3 cups (750 ml) of warm water.

Infuse for 5 minutes. For diarrhea, drink a whole dose 1–2 times a day.



Poultice For wounds, add several drops of calendula tincture to 1 tsp of powder. Mix into a paste and apply (see p. 295).

Capsules (to make, p. 292)
For bronchitis, take a 200 mg capsule 2–3 times a day.



Powder For acid indigestion, take 1 tsp with water 2–3 times daily.



Tablets Take for diarrhea.

■ **External uses** Applied externally, the herb softens and protects the skin. It also works very well as a “drawing” poultice for boils and splinters.

Self-help Uses

- Acidity & indigestion, p. 307.
- Acne & boils, p. 305.
- Constipation in children, p. 318.
- Hemorrhoids, p. 302.